ZikShare
ACADEMIC VAULT

UNIZIK FRESHER EDITION | 2026

THA 214: Fundamentals of Script Writing - Structure, Character and Dialogue

Write a producible short play and learn to revise it

THEATRE & FILM

Theatre & Film Studies

Faculty of Arts
Theatre & Film Studies | 200L

OUTLINE ARCHIVE: 2018 - 2019 - 2025/2026

Written for students, by students.

Practical notes, worked examples, practice questions and a revision plan.

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Independent study support | Not an official UNIZIK publication

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Why this pack exists

Playwriting is a craft with repeatable techniques: premise, conflict, character want, escalation and resolution. This pack gives you a scene-by-scene method, dialogue exercises, formatting conventions and a revision checklist, ending with a ten-minute play brief you can actually complete.

This is a student-written study companion, not a reproduced lecture handout or a leaked examination paper. Use it to organise the topics you are taught, practise the kind of thinking your course rewards, and walk into class with better questions.

What you will be able to do

- Turn a premise into a dramatic conflict with stakes.
- Build a scene that has a clear want, obstacle and change.
- Write dialogue that performs character rather than explaining it.
- Format a script professionally and revise it through structured readings.

How to use this pack

1. Skim the whole pack once in 20 minutes so you know what is inside.
2. Work through one section at a time with your lecture note and recommended text beside you.
3. Attempt the practice questions before reading the answers. Mark what you missed.
4. Use the final checklist to plan your revision week, one tick per study session.

> **Free to download, always**
> This pack is free. There is no fee, no subscription and no payment step before download, and the full PDF is not watermarked or locked. Share the link with a coursemate instead of forwarding the file.

> **Confirm your official course outline**
> Course codes, credit units and outlines can differ by department and session. Treat this pack as supplementary support and confirm the current outline with your lecturer, course rep or departmental handbook before an assessment.

Premise, conflict, stakes

A play needs someone who wants something they cannot easily get.

- Premise: the situation in one sentence, including the disruption.
- Protagonist: the character who drives the action.
- Objective: what they want now, in this scene.
- Obstacle: the person or condition blocking them.
- Stakes: what happens if they fail.
- Theme emerges from the argument the play stages, not from a speech.

Scenes that turn

A scene earns its place by changing something.

- Enter late, leave early: start after the small talk and cut before the resolution.
- Give each character a distinct tactic, not just a distinct opinion.
- Escalate: each beat should raise cost or narrow options.
- Use subtext: characters rarely say exactly what they want.
- End the scene on a shift in power, knowledge or decision.
- Read dialogue aloud to catch lines no human would say.

> **Show, do not explain**
> If a character announces the theme, cut the line and let the action carry it. Audiences trust what they witness.

Format and revision

Standard formatting signals professionalism and speeds rehearsal.

- Scene headings, character names in capitals, dialogue, stage directions in italics or brackets.
- Keep stage directions minimal and physical.
- Number pages for rehearsal and timing.
- Hold a table read and mark where attention drops.
- Revise for clarity, not cleverness: cut ten percent.
- Keep drafts labelled with dates and version numbers.

OUTLINE ARCHIVE

Session record: THA 214

2018 - 2019 - 2025/2026

Year demarcation matters: a course code that existed in 2018 may have been renumbered, merged or dropped by 2019, and the department now also runs a film track. Read the year label before you rely on a code. The current entry below is a compiled map - take it to your course rep or the departmental office and confirm it before registration.

2018 — Archived course description — ARCHIVED

- THA 214 Fundamentals of Script Writing
- Scripting and plot devices, characterisation, theme and language in creating a dramatic script
- Graded exercises developing individual and group scripts

Source: unizik.edu.ng - Theatre & Film Studies course description (page dated 31 May 2018; original URL now returns 404) (retrieved 2026-10-22)

2019 — Archived programme listing — ARCHIVED

- THA 214 Fundamentals of Script Writing, 3 credits, second semester, 200 level
- Later script courses: THA 322 Script Analysis and THA 332 Principles of Adaptation and Improvisation
- Writing sits within the dramaturgy stress area alongside directing

What changed: The 2019 listing adds a 300-level script analysis and adaptation sequence after the 200-level writing course.

Source: arts.unizik.edu.ng - Theatre Arts programme and course map (page dated 18 Oct 2019; original URL now returns 404) (retrieved 2026-10-22)

2025/2026 — Compiled working map — CURRENT WORKING MAP

- Fundamentals of script writing remains the 200-level dramaturgy core
- Expect a portfolio assessment: premise, scene work and a revised draft
- Ask whether your cohort writes for stage, screen or both

Source: Compiled by ZikShare from the archived 2018 and 2019 departmental pages plus the published stress areas; this is a working map, not an official handout (retrieved 2026-10-22)

Archive means: this records what a public departmental page listed in that year. It is not a guarantee of the current curriculum, and ZikShare is not affiliated with UNIZIK.

PRACTICE, NOT PREDICTION

Check your understanding

These questions are written for this pack to test the ideas above. They are not past examination questions and do not predict what your lecturer will set. Answer first, then compare.

1. What is the difference between an objective and an obstacle?

Answer: The objective is what a character wants in the scene; the obstacle is what blocks them from getting it.

2. Why is subtext important in dialogue?

Answer: It creates tension between what is said and what is meant, giving actors something to play and audiences something to interpret.

3. What does 'enter late, leave early' mean?

Answer: Begin a scene after the routine preliminaries and end before the obvious resolution, keeping only dramatically necessary action.

4. How should stage directions be written?

Answer: Sparingly, in the present tense, focused on visible physical action rather than inner emotion.

5. Give one test for a weak line of dialogue.

Answer: If it could be spoken by any character in the play without changing meaning, it is not yet character-specific.

Your 7-step action plan

Tick each step only when you have done it. A tick you cannot defend is worse than an empty box.

- [ ] Write three premises with a clear disruption.
- [ ] Outline a ten-minute play in beats.
- [ ] Draft one scene of no more than three pages.
- [ ] Read it aloud with two coursemates.
- [ ] Cut ten percent of the lines after the reading.
- [ ] Format the script correctly with a title page.
- [ ] Submit a second draft with a short revision note.

Keep going

One pack will not carry a semester. Pair this with your lecture notes, tutorials, and the past questions your department actually releases. If a topic still feels unclear, take a specific question to your lecturer or course rep - "I do not understand the difference between X and Y" gets a better answer than "I do not understand this course".

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YOUR WORKSPACE

Notes, questions and things to ask

Use this page in class or during revision. Write questions you could not answer instead of copying slides.

Three ideas I can now explain without notes:

A question I still cannot answer:

For my lecturer or course rep:

Next revision action and date: